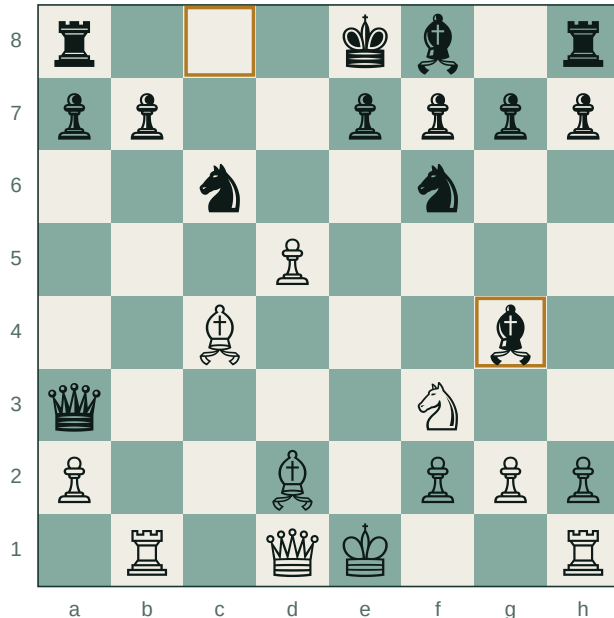


Trapping a piece: White, move 12

Trapping a piece

White to move



Previous move: 11...Bg4. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

12. dxc6 bxc6 13. Bb4 Qxb4+ 14. Rxb4

12.dxc6 The pawn captures the knight on c6. Recorded reply: **12...bxc6**.

13.Bb4 The bishop moves from d2 to b4. Recorded reply: **13...Qxb4+**.

14.Rxb4 The rook captures the queen on b4.

At the end, nominal material is White 29 / Black 25 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, White's balance changes by +8. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does White's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** +8: the balance goes from -4 to +4. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

An attacked piece is not trapped if it can give check, trade itself favorably, or open an escape through a sacrifice.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

A trapped piece lacks safe retreat squares. Winning it usually requires restricting its routes before attacking it, or forcing it into a cage.

HOW TO LOOK

Trace every plausible escape square for the target, including captures and counterchecks. Then find the move that closes the remaining route.

The defending king is on e8. Geometrically undefended: rook on h8 and rook on a8. Check for tactical protection.